while serving in the regiment or the battalion; living, playing and eating with the men, cannot be learnt at any academy or by reading manuals. Today, I am given to understand that command tenures of one star and above are so short that they can hardly do justice to their assignment. In fact, most commanders want to conduct a war game or a sand-model discussion or some other major training event during their brief tenures – at times to score brownie points and prove that they are better than the others. Each of them is in a tearing hurry, often without caring about the adverse impact on their officers and men. Consequently, the commanding officers of units are away quite often, attending war games or other events, and the second-in-command are running the show. In some formations and units the term 'quick' result areas has replaced 'key' result areas!

In our system one has to command a unit or formation successfully to be eligible for the next higher rank. Hence everyone has to be given a chance to command, even if the tenures are ridiculously short. During my two years in command of 1 Corps, I saw three generals changing hands in my armoured division. The protocol welcomes and farewells were quite a strain on time. It required some genius for them to contribute anything substantial or to achieve their key objectives. I doubt if they were able to meaningfully visit all their formations and major units in that short period. Even if they managed to do so, how much time was left for looking at the big picture, with all the running around. It was neither fair to them nor to the organization. Till two years ago, the brigade commanders were getting about a year-and-a-half and the general officers-in-command of divisions were lucky to get over a year in command. We must find a long-term solution to the problem.

Our present system of selection has placed some officers in high positions, even after they had reached their limit. In higher ranks, we need leaders with greater vision, high professional competence, rich and varied experience and importantly, large-heartedness and conduct as a general. Besides, one would definitely prefer those who have served more with troops rather than the ones who have had